What It Means to Be Human · Part Three of Four

God Is Man's World

The Word Spoken in the Garden

A Biblical Account of Man's Revelational Environment and the Special Revelation God Gave Before the Fall

The Kiln Ministries / Great Physician Application

Sources: Holy Scripture; Van Til, "Nature and Scripture," *The Defense of the Faith*, *An Introduction to Systematic Theology*; Vos, *Biblical Theology*; Calvin, *Institutes*; Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics* Vols. 1–2; *Westminster Confession of Faith*

Preface: Going Back to the Garden

Part One of this series described what the human being was made to be: an image-bearer of God, crowned with glory, endowed with true knowledge, righteousness, and holiness, and commissioned to exercise dominion over the created order. Part Two described what happened to that creature in the fall: the image defaced, the mind darkened, the will enslaved, the affections disordered.

Part Two also made a claim that deserves more attention than it could receive there. Following Calvin and Watson, it identified the root of the first sin as *unbelief* — the crediting of the serpent's word over God's word, the inversion of the order on which all genuine human knowledge depended. That claim raises a question we have not yet answered. What was that order? What did it mean for Adam, before he sinned, to know anything at all? And what exactly was the word that he and Eve refused to believe?

This article goes back to the garden to answer those questions. It does so under the guidance of a striking phrase from Cornelius Van Til: *God is man's world*. And it takes up a subject that Geerhardus Vos called *pre-redemptive special revelation* — the fact that God spoke to man, in words, before there was any sin to redeem.

That may seem like a detour from the practical work of caring for souls. It is not. Every person who comes for help is an interpreter of his own life. He has already decided what his suffering means, what his relationships mean, what his past means, and what his future holds. The question this article asks — *by whose word are the facts of a human life to be understood?* — is the question underneath every counseling conversation. And the garden is where that question was first asked and first answered.

I. “God Is Man’s World”

Van Til’s phrase is short, and it is easy to misread. It does not mean that God and the world are the same thing. Van Til was the most insistent of theologians on what he called the Creator–creature distinction: God is self-existent, self-sufficient, and self-interpreting; the creature is none of these. Nothing in the phrase blurs that line.

What the phrase means is that the true *environment* of the human being is not, in the first place, the physical world. It is God himself. Man does not live in a neutral cosmos that happens to contain, somewhere in it or above it, a God whom he may or may not take into account. He lives, as Paul told the philosophers in Athens, in God: *”In him we live and move and have our being”* (Acts 17:28). Every breath, every thought, every perception, every relationship takes place inside the sphere of God’s creating, sustaining, and interpreting presence. *”For from him and through him and to him are all things”* (Romans 11:36). Christ *”upholds the universe by the word of his power”* (Hebrews 1:3), and *”in him all things hold together”* (Colossians 1:17).

The consequence Van Til drew from this is the one that matters most for our purposes: there are no *brute facts*. A brute fact would be a fact that simply exists, uninterpreted, waiting for some mind to come along and decide what it means. On the biblical view, no such fact exists anywhere. Every fact in the universe was planned by God before it existed, brought into being by God’s word, and is held in being moment by moment by God’s providence. Its meaning is therefore not something man assigns to it; its meaning is something God has already given it. Every fact is a God-interpreted fact before it is ever a man-interpreted fact.

This is what it means to say that God is man’s world. The human being never meets anything — a sunrise, a sickness, a spouse, a memory, his own heart — that is not already God’s, already defined by God’s purpose, and already speaking of God. To be human is to live, every moment, in a revelational environment.

II. Revelation Everywhere: Creation and the Self

Scripture is plain that this environment speaks. *”The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork”* (Psalm 19:1). Paul says that God’s *”invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made”* (Romans 1:20). Calvin, for his part, liked to call the created world the *theater of God’s glory* — a stage on which every created thing performs its part in displaying the wisdom, power, and goodness of its Maker.

But revelation is not only *around* man. It is *in* him. Part One noted Bavinck’s observation that at the root of human self-consciousness lies a sense of absolute dependence — an awareness, prior to every argument, that the self does not originate itself. Calvin called it the *sense of divinity* written on every human heart. Van Til pressed the point further: man cannot be conscious of himself without at the same time being conscious of God, because the self he is conscious of is an image. An image is, by definition, a reference to an original. To know yourself at all is to know yourself as

derived.

So the image-bearer is surrounded by revelation and constituted by revelation. Creation speaks of God, and man himself — his conscience, his reason, his longing for meaning, his capacity for love — speaks of God. There is nowhere to stand, inside or outside the self, that is not already God's address to him.

Van Til argued in his essay "Nature and Scripture" that this revelation in nature is in its own way *necessary*, *authoritative*, *sufficient*, and *clear* — the same attributes the church has confessed of Scripture. It is not a dim or uncertain witness. When man fails to read it, the failure is not in the revelation.

III. Nature Was Never Meant to Speak Alone

And yet — here is the heart of the matter — nature was never meant to speak alone.

The first thing God does after creating man is not to leave him to study the world and draw his own conclusions. The first thing God does is *talk to him*. *"And God blessed them. And God said to them, 'Be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it, and have dominion'"* (Genesis 1:28). He goes on: *"Behold, I have given you every plant yielding seed that is on the face of all the earth, and every tree with seed in its fruit. You shall have them for food"* (Genesis 1:29). And in the garden, he speaks again: *"You may surely eat of every tree of the garden, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die"* (Genesis 2:16–17).

Notice what is happening. Adam had eyes, a sound mind, an uncorrupted heart, and a world in perfect order spread out before him. He was not fallen. His reason was not darkened. And still God did not leave him to work out from the creation what the creation was *for*, what his own life was *for*, or what was required of him. God told him. The plants were food because God said so. The earth was to be filled and subdued because God said so. One tree in the garden — a tree that, as far as the eye could tell, was like the others — carried a meaning that no examination of its bark or fruit could have revealed. Its meaning was given entirely by the word God spoke about it.

This is what Vos called *pre-redemptive special revelation*: direct, verbal communication from God to man, given before the fall, and therefore not given as a remedy for sin. Van Til made the same point in "Nature and Scripture": from the beginning, God's revelation in nature was meant to be taken together with God's spoken word. Even in paradise, man was confronted with supernatural, positive revelation. The two were never designed to function independently. Nature supplied the facts; the word supplied their purpose, their meaning, and their place in God's plan for man. Bavinck likewise insisted that revelation is not first of all a medicine for sin. It belongs to the very relationship between God and a creature made for fellowship with him.

This changes how we ought to think about Scripture. We often speak of the Bible as if its only reason for existing were that sin has made it necessary — as if, had Adam never fallen, the creation would have been enough. Genesis says otherwise. Unfallen man already lived by the word of God.

The need for God to speak was not created by sin; it was built into what it means to be a creature. Sin did not create the need for revelation. It made man refuse it.

IV. What the Word in the Garden Said

What did that first special revelation contain? Vos, in his *Biblical Theology*, organizes it around four principles, each attached to an element of the garden narrative: the principle of life, symbolized by the tree of life; the principle of probation, symbolized by the tree of the knowledge of good and evil; the principle of temptation, embodied in the serpent; and the principle of death, attached as the sanction of the command. Each of these deserves a word.

Life. The tree of life stood *"in the midst of the garden"* (Genesis 2:9). Adam was alive, but the tree pointed beyond the life he had to a higher, confirmed, unlosable life that lay ahead of him. This is why Part One could say that the redemptive project is not a return to Eden but an advance beyond it. Eden itself was pointed forward. Man was created good but not yet finished; he stood at the beginning of a road whose end was eternal life in unbreakable fellowship with God. When Christ promises, *"To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God"* (Revelation 2:7), he is announcing that the goal held out in the garden has been won.

Probation. The tree of the knowledge of good and evil was the test. The question it posed was not whether Adam would come to know good and evil — he would, one way or another — but *how*. Would he know good and evil by receiving God's word about them, defining good as what God commands and evil as what God forbids? Or would he know them by deciding for himself, by experiment and by his own judgment, apart from God's word? The tree put the whole of human knowledge under the authority of a single sentence spoken by God. To obey was to confess that God is the interpreter of reality. To eat was to claim that role for oneself.

Temptation. The serpent embodied the alternative. It did not argue against the existence of God; it argued against the reliability and the goodness of God's word. Its whole strategy, as we will see, was interpretive.

Death. The sanction was as clear as the command. *"In the day that you eat of it you shall surely die."* Death was not a natural process that God would merely allow; it was the judicial consequence of rejecting the word on which life itself depended.

The Westminster Confession gathers all of this under the idea of covenant. *"The distance between God and the creature is so great,"* it says, *"that although reasonable creatures do owe obedience unto Him as their Creator, yet they could never have any fruition of Him as their blessedness and reward, but by some voluntary condescension on God's part, which He hath been pleased to express by way of covenant"* (WCF 7.1). Even before the fall, man's relationship with God did not run on nature alone. It ran on God's condescending, promising, commanding word. The covenant of life in the garden was, at bottom, a relationship constituted by speech.

V. Thinking God's Thoughts After Him

None of this means that Adam was passive. The same chapter that records God's command records Adam's first great intellectual act: *"Now out of the ground the LORD God had formed every beast of the field and every bird of the heavens and brought them to the man to see what he would call them. And whatever the man called every living creature, that was its name"* (Genesis 2:19).

This is a remarkable text. God brings the creatures to Adam and *waits to see* what he will call them. Adam's naming is real. It is not a guessing game in which he tries to discover a name already hidden somewhere; it is a genuine exercise of the image of God — understanding, classifying, ordering, speaking. Whatever he called them, that was their name.

But Adam's naming happens inside a world God has already named. God has already called the light Day and the darkness Night. God has already declared each creature good. God has already told Adam what he is, what he is for, and what is required of him. Adam's interpretation is creative, but it is *re*-interpretation: it follows, receives, and extends the interpretation God has already given. This is what the phrase so dear to Van Til means — man is called to *think God's thoughts after him*. Van Til called this kind of knowledge *analogical*. Human knowledge is true knowledge, but it is never independent knowledge. It is the creature's finite echo of what God knows originally and perfectly.

This is the pattern of dominion. To subdue the earth is not to impose on it whatever meaning we like. It is to discover, develop, and display the meanings God has already built into it, in obedience to the purposes God has already announced. The scientist, the farmer, the artist, the parent, the craftsman — all are, when they work rightly, receptive reinterpreters. Their work is glorious precisely because it is derivative.

And this, finally, is what it means to live in a world that is God. It is not to be crushed by God's presence, as though there were no room left for the creature. It is to be given a vast, ordered, meaningful home in which every act of knowing is an act of fellowship — the creature listening to the Creator and answering him.

VI. "Did God Actually Say?" — The Fall as an Interpretive Revolution

Read in this light, the first words of the serpent are no longer surprising. *"Did God actually say, 'You shall not eat of any tree in the garden'?"* (Genesis 3:1).

The serpent's opening move is not to deny God but to put God's word up for review. It begins by misquoting the command — inflating it into a prohibition of *every* tree — so that God's word sounds harsh and arbitrary. Then it contradicts the word outright: *"You will not surely die"* (Genesis 3:4). Then it reinterprets God's motive: *"For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil"* (Genesis 3:5). By the end, the word God spoke as a gift and a boundary has been recast as a threat and a jealous restriction.

Now watch what the woman does: *"So when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was a delight to the eyes, and that the tree was to be desired to make one wise, she took of its fruit and ate"* (Genesis 3:6).

Every one of those observations was, in a sense, true. The tree *was* good for food — it was a tree, and God had made its fruit. It *was* a delight to the eyes. But the decisive fact about that tree was not anything the eye could see. The decisive fact was what God had said about it. The woman set the word aside and evaluated the tree by her own perception and her own desire, as if the tree were a brute fact whose meaning she was free to determine. In that moment, she and her husband attempted to become what only God is: the original interpreter of reality.

This is why Part Two could call the fall an inversion of the epistemological order. It was not only a moral failure; it was an intellectual revolution. Man tried to stop living in God's world — a world defined by God's word — and to start living in a world of his own, where facts mean what the self decides they mean. The serpent's promise, *"you will be like God,"* was a promise that man could be his own world.

He cannot. The attempt did not make man independent. It made him blind.

VII. Fallen Man Still Lives in God's World

The fall did not remove man from his revelational environment. It could not. God is still man's world, and every fact is still God's fact. What changed is man's posture toward it.

Paul describes that posture in Romans 1. The knowledge of God, he says, is *"plain to them, because God has shown it to them"* (Romans 1:19). The revelation has not failed. But fallen men *"by their unrighteousness suppress the truth"* (Romans 1:18): *"although they knew God, they did not honor him as God or give thanks to him, but they became futile in their thinking, and their foolish hearts were darkened"* (Romans 1:21). The result is not ignorance but suppression — a constant, effortful, self-deceiving resistance to a knowledge that cannot be escaped.

This is why Part One could say that the person who comes for help is never blank. He knows God, and he knows himself to be God's creature, even when he says otherwise and even when he believes otherwise. He lives every moment in a world that is shouting the glory of God at him, and he is spending enormous energy not hearing it. The fall did not silence revelation. It set man at war with it.

It also means that every fallen interpretation of life, however sophisticated, is borrowed. The unbeliever still uses God's world, God's logic, God's moral order, and God's gifts of reason and language — he simply refuses to acknowledge the Owner. Van Til's well-known picture is of a child sitting on his father's lap and slapping his face: the unbeliever can only deny God while being held up by him. Fallen man still knows a great deal. What he cannot do is know anything *rightly*, because he has cut each fact off from the word that gives it its meaning.

VIII. If Adam Needed the Word, How Much More Do We

Here the garden speaks directly to us. If unfallen Adam — with a clear mind, a pure heart, and a perfect world — could not know the meaning of his own life without God speaking to him, how much less can we?

Moses draws exactly this lesson for Israel in the wilderness: God humbled them and fed them with manna *"that he might make you know that man does not live by bread alone, but man lives by every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD"* (Deuteronomy 8:3). Bread is part of the created order. It sustains life, and God gives it. But bread alone has never been enough for a creature made in God's image. Man lives by the word.

And when Jesus, the Last Adam, is led into the wilderness to be tempted, he answers the tempter with that very text: *"It is written, 'Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God'"* (Matthew 4:4). The first Adam, in a garden of plenty, set aside God's word and trusted his own reading of the fruit. The Last Adam, hungry in a wilderness, refused to read his circumstances apart from what God had said. Where Adam reinterpreted God's word by the evidence of his senses, Christ interpreted the evidence of his senses by God's word. He lived, perfectly, as a man for whom God is his world.

Scripture, then, is not an emergency supplement to a natural knowledge that would otherwise be adequate. It is the continuation and restoration of the original arrangement — the word God has always spoken to his image-bearers — now also carrying the message of redemption that sin made necessary. Calvin compared Scripture to spectacles: just as a person with weak eyes can barely make out the words on a page until he puts on his glasses, so Scripture gathers up our confused knowledge of God and brings it into focus. The book of nature has not stopped speaking. But fallen eyes cannot read it rightly until they read it through the book of Scripture. *"In your light do we see light"* (Psalm 36:9).

Psalm 19 holds both together in a single song. Its first half celebrates the heavens declaring the glory of God; its second half celebrates the law of the LORD, perfect, reviving the soul. The psalmist does not set the two against each other, and he does not treat the second as an afterthought to the first. They are one revelation from one God, and the creature needs both.

IX. Implications for Soul Care

Van Til wrote as an apologist, not as a counselor. But the doctrine he drew from the garden reaches straight into the counseling room.

Every counselee is an interpreter. People do not come to counseling with raw facts; they come with interpreted facts. *"My husband doesn't love me." "God has abandoned me." "I'm worthless." "I'll never change."* The pain is real, but the meaning attached to the pain has already been supplied — usually by the person's own desires, fears, and history, and often by voices that sound remarkably like the serpent's: *Did God actually say? God is holding out on you. You will not surely die.* Much of the work of counsel is gently surfacing these interpretations so they can be

examined in God's light.

The counselor brings God's interpretation, not his own. If there are no brute facts, then the counselor's job is not merely to gather information and offer reasonable advice. It is to help the person hear what God has already said about him, his circumstances, his sin, and his hope. The counselor, too, is a receptive reinterpreter. His authority is never his own insight; it is the word he carries. This is both humbling and freeing. He does not have to invent the meaning of anyone's suffering. He has to listen to God and help another listen.

Neither experience nor feelings speak alone. The modern counselee is often told to trust his experience, his intuitions, or his emotions as the final word on who he is. The garden shows that this was never God's design, even for an unfallen man. Experience matters; feelings are real data; the body and its condition matter, as Part One insisted. But none of these interprets itself. Like the fruit on the tree, they must be read in light of what God has said.

The counselee never steps out of God's world. There is no circumstance — no diagnosis, betrayal, loss, or failure — that sits outside God's interpreting purpose. That is not a cold doctrine. It is the ground of comfort. The suffering person is not lost in a meaningless cosmos; he is in his Father's world, where every fact has already been taken into account by a God who works all things together for the good of those who love him. The counselor can say, with full confidence, that the person's life *means something*, because God has already given it meaning.

Repentance includes a change of interpreter. In Part Two we saw that the fall was rooted in unbelief. It follows that part of genuine repentance is the surrender of autonomy in interpretation — a return from being one's own world to living in God's. Paul describes this as taking *"every thought captive to obey Christ"* (2 Corinthians 10:5). Change is not only new behavior; it is a new way of reading one's life.

Conclusion: Living in God's World Again

The picture that emerges from the garden is this. Man was made as the image of God, placed in a world full of God's glory, and spoken to by God from the first day of his life. His knowledge was meant to be a listening knowledge, his dominion a receptive dominion, his life a life lived by every word that comes from the mouth of God. God was his world, and in that world he was meant to flourish.

The fall was his attempt to become his own world. It failed, and the failure is the story of every life that has come after it — every darkened mind, every suppressed truth, every interpretation of suffering that leaves God out.

But God did not stop speaking. The same God who spoke in the garden spoke again immediately after the fall, promising that the seed of the woman would crush the serpent's head (Genesis 3:15). He kept speaking through the prophets, and *"in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son"* (Hebrews 1:2) — the eternal Word through whom all things were made, who became flesh and dwelt among us. In him, the word of the garden and the word of redemption meet.

Part Four will take up that redemption: what God does, in Christ, to bring fallen interpreters home — to renew the image, to open blind eyes, and to make men and women who once tried to be their own world able to live, gladly and forever, in his.

> *"For with you is the fountain of life; in your light do we see light."*
>
> — Psalm 36:9

Version 1.0 — Part Three of Four: What It Means to Be Human
The Kiln Ministries / Great Physician Application · jeff@thekiln.org · thekiln.org